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Milgram's Obedience Experiment and the Russia-Ukraine War

In Milgram's study, participants were instructed by an authority figure to administer increasingly severe electric shocks to another person. Despite their personal discomfort, many participants continued to administer shocks because they were told to do so by an authority figure.

Political leaders and authority figures often frame the conflict in moral terms, portraying one side as just and the other as unjust or evil. For instance, Ukraine and Western leaders have framed Russia as an aggressor, rallying people to support military action against it, and yet that's exactly what Ukraine and Western leaders are doing. On the contrary, Russian authorities have justified their actions by framing Ukraine as a threat or as aligned with hostile western powers.

This situation can be seen as a real-world example of how authority figures influence people's actions, even in the context of war. Just as participants in Milgram's experiment continued to administer shocks because an authority figure told them to, soldiers and civilians may support or participate in the war because they are told by their leaders that it is necessary or just, even if they have personal reservations about the morality of war in general. This obedience is often justified by the portrayal of the opposing side as a clear enemy or evil force. The rhetoric used by authority figures can simplify complex situations, leading people to obey commands or support actions they might otherwise question.

Let's explore how the Russia-Ukraine war compares to the Milgram experiment. In both Milgram's experiment and the Russia-Ukraine war, individuals are expected to obey authority figures, even when the actions they are ordered to carry out might conflict with their personal morals. In both Milgram's experiment and the Russia-Ukraine war, individuals are expected to obey authority figures, even when the actions they are ordered to carry out might conflict with their personal morals. In Milgram's study, participants administered shocks because they were instructed to do so by an authority figure. Similarly, soldiers and civilians on both sides of the war are following orders from their leaders, which can include engaging in violent acts.

That said, there are a few differences between the Milgram experiment and the Russia-Ukraine war. Milgram's experiment was conducted in a controlled laboratory setting, focusing on individual participants' responses to authority. The Russia-Ukraine war, on the other hand, involves real-world, large-scale, geopolitical conflict with significant historical, cultural, and nationalistic factors influencing behavior. The consequences in Milgram's experiment were simulated and psychological (no actual shocks were administered), while the consequences of the Russia-Ukraine war are real and severe, involving the loss of life, destruction of the environment, and long-term societal and cultural impacts.

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In both the Milgram experiment and the Russia-Ukraine war, authority figures are those who give orders. In Milgram's experiment, this was the experimenter. In the war, these are political leaders and military commanders who direct actions. In Milgram's experiment, participants who administered shocks represented subordinates following authority. In the war, soldiers and civilians who participate in or support the conflict are the subordinates. Their behaviors reflect obedience, often carrying out orders even when they might personally disagree with them.

If we analyze the specific behaviors of the participants in both Milgram's experiment and the Russia-Ukraine war, we'll find there are parallels. In Milgram's experiment, participants administered electric chocks to the "learner" under the instruction of the experimenter. Many continued to do so, even as the shocks became more severe, reflecting their submission to authority. In the Russia-Ukraine war, soldiers are engaging in combat, following orders to attack, defend, or occupy territories. Civilians may support the war effort through propaganda, volunteering, or complying with group narratives, even if they personally question the morality of the conflict.

In both cases, participants might experience internal conflict, guilt, or distress from their actions. In Milgram's experiment, some participants showed visible discomfort when administering shocks. Similarly, soldiers or civilians may struggle with the moral implications of their actions in the war. In contrast, those who resist or refuse to comply with authority (such as soldiers attempting to desert the war or civilians who speak out against the war) might face public shame, ostracization, or punishment from their communities or governments.

The clear hierarchical structure in the military and government creates a dynamic where obedience is expected, and stepping outside of that is often punished. This power dynamic pushes individuals to follow orders and continues to drive conflict. The strong nationalistic narratives and propaganda reinforce the roles, making it difficult for individuals to question or oppose the authority, leading to widespread participation in the war effort.

War is a complex scenario due to nationalist pressures and authority figures driving conformity and obedience. Ideally, an alternative situation would be that people felt empowered to stand up for what they believed in without societal pressure to conform. If soldiers and civilians were encouraged and empowered to critically question the morality of their orders and the war itself, it could lead to more widespread dissent, protests, refusals to fight, or even movements pushing for peace negotiations. This could be supported by independent communication channels and a widespread group of people fostering a culture that values ethical reasoning and moral courage.

That said, questioning authority might not only affect the immediate context of the war but could have broader implications, as suggested by the Flouting Thesis. According to this thesis, recognizing an unjust law or directive can lead to a general decline in obedience to authority, impacting compliance with unrelated laws and norms (Nadler, 2005). In this scenario, growing awareness of the war's moral complexities could trigger a wider culture of resistance, especially in our digital age. Soldiers and civilians, realizing their leaders' orders may be illegitimate or propaganda, might start challenging other forms of authority and questioning previously accepted societal norms and laws (Nadler, 2005).

The emergence of disobedient role models who publicly defy unjust orders could further strengthen this movement, showcasing the power of moral courage and setting a precedent for others to follow. So how do we balance obedience and moral courage without allowing defiance to negatively impact society? One research study suggests enhancing public awareness of persuasion and manipulation tactics (King, 2004). This study, conducted by students researching the concepts of psychological operations, advocates for education on social psychology principles to help individuals resist manipulation and make more informed decisions (King, 2004).

The power of social psychology and authority influences profoundly affects individual behavior, especially when surrounded by a collective mindset that differs from personal beliefs. Navigating this tension requires not only moral courage but also heightened awareness of the psychological dynamics at play. By understanding these dynamics, individuals can be empowered to stand by their beliefs and stand up to pressure, all while minimizing the risk of social unrest.

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